interface (UPI) was a very new system and had only existed for about eight or nine months,' he said. 'We have been absolutely stunned by how it has expanded. The last number we gave out in February 2019 was 45 million users and what was even more surprising was the amount of actual money passing through the system, which at that point was already above $80 billion annualised. There was a Morgan Stanley report a few months back which said 5-6% of India's GDP is now moving through UPI. That's stunning and it's happened in 18 months.'[109]

The biggest growth has been in UPI, a real-time payment system developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPIC), and e-money transactions, which were a very small share of total digital payments in 2016-17. Since then, UPI has become the largest mode of digital payments by volume, followed by e-money and debit card payments. Cash did make a comeback as the preferred choice of payments two years after demonetisation, but overall, digital transactions have grown by 46 per cent in value and 140 per cent in volume since demonetisation.[110] UPI, for example, clocked over a billion transactions in October 2019, and every month since then. By 31 January 2020, there were 38 crore Jan Dhan account holders in India, with 29 crore of these holding RuPay debit cards.[111]

It is important to remember here that the plumbing for the digital expansion under Modi was laid down in the Manmohan Singh era. Journalist Sanjiv Shankaran remembers going to a village in Odisha in 2009 with then RBI governor D. Subbarao to inaugurate a point-of-cash machine. While the machines themselves were available, the backend network needed to operate them was simply not up and running. The technical basis for the digital payments structure—IndiaStacks (a set of APIs that enables a unique digital infrastructure for cashless service delivery)—was developed under the UPA and further enabled under Modi. It is this network that has enabled the expansion of digital payments.[112]

Fourth, in terms of political emphasis at least, we saw a significant spike in mentions of health and education in the second half of Modi's first term in government—much more than the emphasis on these during the UPA, which focused on a rights-based